immediately promoted to head cheetah, with a drummer marching ahead of it.

The imperial train then headed for Ajmer, to seek the blessings of the saint for the Gujarat campaign. One of Akbar's concubines, who was heavily pregnant, was left in Ajmer where she soon gave birth to a boy, Daniyal, named after the shaikh in whose house he was born. When the child was one month old, Akbar had him sent to Amer, to be looked after by Raja Bharmal's wife. Shielded now with the blessings of Khwaja Sahib and a lustrous son, Akbar sent an advance guard of 10,000 horsemen ahead of the army and began marching towards Patan. This was the first time that Akbar had visited the town since the murder of his old ataliq, Bairam Khan. Even more poignant was the fact that he was accompanied by Bairam Khan's son, Abdur Rahim, now sixteen years old. Abdur Rahim was a precociously intelligent, sensitive, and alert young man who would no doubt have remembered the terrible day when his father had been murdered before his very eyes. The Padshah questioned the young man gently about the terrible tragedy he had witnessed, and perhaps Abdur Rahim remembered enough to tell the Padshah of the horror of witnessing the Afghan youth stabbing his father with such fury that the dagger had gone through him and come out of his back. Akbar promised the young man the fief of Patan once he came of age and then rode towards Ahmedabad to relieve Itimad Khan Gujarati, who had been besieged by mutinous Mughal nobles. But news of the approaching imperial army was enough to chasten the rebels, who quietly left the city and Ahmedabad was taken without a fight. The great noblemen of Gujarat, Ikhtiyar ul-Mulk, Itimad Khan Gujarati, and Shah Turab Abu, among others, now submitted to Akbar. Also present were some Ethiopians such as Ulugh Khan Habshi,[*] and Jajar Khan Habshi, some of whom would become great amirs at Akbar's court while others were entrusted with the guarding of the imperial harem. Having settled the affairs of Ahmedabad and handed over its governorship to Mirza Aziz Koka,[†] Akbar marched to the port of Cambay, to see the ocean.

When Akbar turned towards the ocean in Gujarat, it would also have been to survey the ambitions of the firangis, the Portuguese, who had long posed a violent threat as they tried to establish a foothold in the area. From the time in 1502 when Vasco da Gama 'set alight, and watched burn, a crowded pilgrim ship', the Portuguese were rapacious in their interactions with Muslim traders. A rich and highly developed region, Gujarat and its